

delivering the first apartments two years ahead [of the RERA deadline]. No builder in India has ever delivered a project of this scale and size in three years, out of which two years were [during a] pandemic.

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That is a very precise date and time to arrive at so much in advance...

It's my daughter's birthday [Niharika Singhania, 17]. We always set ourselves a deadline. Typically, somebody's birthday, some occasion... To be honest with you, I need to find an excuse to

then you don't know. Sometimes, not knowing the business is a big advantage.

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The organisation turned around its finances in this time, coming off a bad period. What were the key pillars of your strategy?

Every business had its own strategy. And it was not something that we said we will do after 12 months. When it comes to survival, and you wonder what's going to happen next, you have to say, what am I going to do today? And every day, every step you took

now, what would be the key pivots around which you will take this momentum forward?

See, there are four lines of business—lifestyle, engineering-auto, FMCG [sold off recently to Godrej Consumer Products], and real estate. Each business has its own strategy. Lifestyle has tremendous challenges, or opportunities more than challenges, in the sense that can we come up with new product lines, whether it's home, ethnic, made to measure... Our legacy businesses, like fabric, may grow at 6-7-8 per cent, maybe 9 per cent. But then everything else

made-to-measure, and they'll say you pay 40 per cent premium. Here I give you made to measure; I've been doing it all my life. Plus I can do it the same day for you because I've set the backend up. Nobody else can do that. Today I have built up a 4 million metre linen business, again made to measure. This is mass customisation.

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It's very interesting you say this, because when I was younger, let's say about 20-25 years ago, tailor-made apparel for middle class people like us was the thing to do...

“THERE WAS A DAY [DURING COVID-19] WHEN A PRIVATE BANK REFUSED TO ROLL OVER A LOAN OF ₹5 CRORE ... THE SAME PEOPLE NOW STAND IN LINE LOOKING FOR BUSINESS, BUT IT'S NOT GOING TO BE”

pin the coat on. I thought my daughter's birthday was a far enough time, but realistically near time, and I thought it was achievable. It was a stretch, but what it does is it gears the organisation. We made a public announcement. We put it on our website. We put a countdown timer. Then it aligns the whole organisation. Every builder said we can't deliver. But we did.

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Did it not strike you as a risk? Especially in a new business?

I think sometimes, it's easier to achieve things if you are naive. Because

forward, you came out of the deep water. If you're in six feet of deep water, you got to take one step up the slope, before you can even think of running outside. That's how it goes. But you know what... nothing wins like a positive mindset. If you have a positive mindset and say, 'No, I will survive', period. Vision is 20:20 in hindsight, but we built a real estate business, we built a full new team of people, we built a profitable business, you've seen four quarters of proper delivery, it's all happened, not by chance.

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If we were to look ahead

will grow at an exponential pace. If you see our own example of shirting [fabric] over the last six-seven years, we have built a ₹600-700 crore over-the-counter shirting business. Everybody talks about how readymade shirting is growing... apparel, apparel, apparel. But why are we selling 25 million metres of shirting fabric across the counter?

That's because it's a better value proposition for you to go and buy 1.8 metres of fabric and stitch it customised to yourself. What the world charges you a premium for, I'll give you a discount on. You go to Zegna and you say

Even I did it, and that too stitching. I don't like readymade. I prefer custom. Custom is luxury. In this country, we have tailors. (Pointing to his attire) my shoes are made to measure; these chinos are made to measure; this T-shirt is made to measure. I can do anything made-to-measure—shirts, trousers, jackets. We are the only brand in the world that goes from ₹300 a metre to ₹10 lakh a metre; that's 3,000 times in price point under the same brand; no brand in the world could do it. Nokia had to do Vertu, Toyota had to do Lexus... Today you can buy a Lexus ES